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CEO & SECRETARY
GENERAL, ADVERTISING
STANDARDS COUNCIL
OF INDIA

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**A ROBUST
FRAMEWORK THAT
COMBINES CLEAR
AND EFFECTIVELY
ENFORCED
REGULATION
AND EMPOWERED
CONSUMERS IS
ESSENTIAL**

A GENUINE GREEN FUTURE

While increased focus on environmental responsibility is a positive development, the risk of greenwashing replacing genuine green action is real and significant

THE HEIGHTENED AWARENESS

around the state of the planet has spurred a global awakening, with consumers increasingly demanding environmentally responsible practices from businesses. The consumer lacks the tools for critical evaluation and can get caught in a web of carefully crafted illusions of greenwashing. There is a growing concern that the performative act of appearing green is overshadowing substantive environmental action.

Greenwashing is the practice of misleading consumers about the environmental benefits of a product, service, or company. It's the art of painting a verdant veneer over practices that remain fundamentally unsustainable. The motivations are clear: to capitalise on the growing eco-conscious consumer base, enhance brand image, and potentially attract investors who prioritise environmental, social, and governance (ESG) factors, all while avoiding the often costly and complex undertaking of genuine environmental transformation.

India is not immune to this trend. Consider the proliferation of "eco-friendly" packaging that, upon closer inspection, might utilise a minimal percentage of recycled material or remain non-biodegradable. Similarly, some real estate developers mar-

ket their projects as "green" based on superficial features like rainwater harvesting while neglecting crucial aspects like energy efficiency in construction and long-term ecological impact on the environment.

The automotive sector, both globally and in India, has witnessed instances where companies heavily promote electric or hybrid vehicles while their overall production and supply chain remain heavily reliant on fossil fuels. These examples highlight how marketing narratives can create a perception that doesn't align with the holistic impact.

In general, the attempt is to appear more "green" than is the case. Generic terms like "eco-friendly," "green," and "recyclable" create the impression that the entire product or company is green, whereas such practices may apply to a small percentage of the product or service.

The issue is equally pronounced globally. Fast fashion brands touting "sustainable collections" often utilise a small percentage of recycled materials in a fraction of their vast output, while their core business model remains predicated on over-consumption and waste. Major oil and gas companies invest heavily in public relations campaigns showcasing their investments in renewable energy, often dwarfed by their